BJP launched an e-library of digitised party records from the 1950s to the present day. This resource proved invaluable in reconstructing the party's early evolution and its current thinking as seen through party documents. Finally, the Nehru Memorial Museum and Library (NMML) archive at Teen Murti House in Delhi, the newspaper records stored there and *The Times of India*'s digitised archive available on the academic database ProQuest provided a great deal of original material for this story on how key debates unfolded over time.

What Does This Book Do?

When the BJP was launched in 1980, it was derided in one memorable tongue-in-cheek press account as a 'vegetarian but tasty party'.[14] The green and saffron colours of the new party were the same as that of the Janata Party, the united Opposition front that its predecessor Jan Sangh had merged into in 1977 to fight Indira Gandhi's Emergency. When the BJP emerged out of Janata Party in 1980, it retained the colours but flipped them into vertical lines, unlike the horizontal pattern of the original. The BJP leaders added a lotus to their new flag. They told reporters that they had chosen the flower as their official symbol, and for the flag, because it was a symbol of resistance used by Indian revolutionaries against the British in the 1857 War of Independence. The lotus, of course, also has a strong mythological and cultural significance in Hinduism. It is associated with Vishnu, the protector, and Lakshmi, the goddess of wealth, and is also the national flower of India.

My account of the BJP's political journey is divided into five parts.

Part I shows how the BJP's growth was built on its transformation into the predominant rural party in its core-strength areas: the Hindi-speaking states of north India. This is a big claim to make about a party that was once derided as an urban force with a narrow upper-caste base. This part then focuses on how such a turn was achieved: through a politics of targeted social welfare aimed at 'labharthees' (beneficiaries of the government's welfare schemes), aided by digital tools, new caste alliances and a major expansion of